imagined, purchasing steamers was not a simple task. Even if a company had enough money, ships could not be picked off the shelves. By definition, ships were an international commodity, surveyed and monitored by classification societies such as Lloyd's Register of Shipping and Bureau Veritas. Steamers took years to build and involved huge operational costs and advanced technical skills. Boilers needed regular maintenance, with continual repairs adding to operational costs. Technical personnel, highly stratified by their skills—usually certified by accredited bodies—were required to operate them. Since seafaring was a risky business, insurance costs too were high. (It was said that the British insurance industry, Lloyd's, with its monopoly, discriminated against Indian-owned vessels, though we have no evidence from Tuticorin on this.[39]) Given their large size, huge cost and allied expenditure—not to mention their long gestation period—steamers were not always bought outright but were often leased and chartered. Such transactions, requiring financial and technical know-how, necessarily involved intermediaries. To put it mildly, these dealings were more treacherous than a stormy sea. It was on this dangerous voyage that VOC embarked soon after the registration of the company.

In late October 1906, VOC left for Bombay where he spent the better part of the subsequent five months,[40] travelling often to Tuticorin (and possibly Colombo as well). VOC came to know the city so well that Subramania Bharati, writing of their visit to the Surat Congress a year later, referred to VOC's great familiarity with Bombay that helped the delegates to find suitable board and lodging.

> By the end of October 1906, I [affirmed VOC in court] left Tuticorin for Bombay and stayed there for about five months, and purchased two steamers through a European friend of mine on condition that the price amount may be paid in instalments. It was due at Tuticorin on 16-5-07.[41]

What this affidavit by VOC stated in two brief sentences was in fact a long and complicated process demanding commitment, astuteness and business acumen.